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A refugee-run restaurant at Ripon Buildings offers sambol, odiyal koozh and more **P2**

WHY RAJKUMMAR TURNED PRODUCER **P4**



₹40

Towels (thundu) make an appearance only during elections. Shawls instead rule the roost. Priced between ₹30-₹40

₹200

Saris with political party symbols are now made of polyester. Prices fluctuate between ₹150-₹200

Vote couture

Ahead of the 2026 Tamil Nadu Assembly elections, political style is no longer top-down — from DMK's Stalin to TVK's Vijay, leaders, supporters, and fans are fuelling a shift to customised outfits, party merch, and social media-driven fashion

FULL STORY ON
» PAGE 2



₹12,000

This ornate blouse with TVK symbolism, including the flag and symbol, is an election special

₹180

Colours of all party memorabilia have grown brighter. Small town retailers are making profits from the boom

PICTURES BY JOHAN SATHYADAS



Pièce de résistance

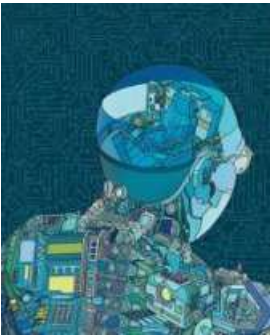
Marking Dalit History Month, The Whole Story at Lalit Kala Akademi showcases 36 artists to spark conversation

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B R Ambedkar said, “Freedom of mind is the real freedom.” In the context of art, it takes on another meaning — art that sparks dialogue, that quietly resists, and, in doing so, becomes an act of revolution. Over the next few days, the walls of Lalit Kala Akademi stand as a testament to this spirit, marking Dalit History Month.

Organised by Neelam Cultural Centre and titled The Whole Story, the exhibition brings together installations, paintings, and even an animation showcase, featuring the works of 36 Dalit artists from Neelam Arts Collective, as part of the Vaanam Art Festival.

The exhibition sparks new conversations, and one such work is Natarajan Gangadharan's installation Mother Line, which pays tribute to Dalit women — leaders, writers, and legislators, whose contributions remain largely overlooked in



mainstream history. The installation brings into focus, figures like Krishnammal Jagannathan, who fought for Dalit land rights; Sathyavani Muthu, the first woman Minister in a DMK Government and an Ambedkarite voice; Annapoorani from the Periyar movement; and Tamil political activist

Annai Meenambal Shivaraj. Natarajan's distinct visual language brings together Dalit consciousness, ecological sensitivity, and meditative influences from Buddhist thought. “With The Whole Story, we want people to see Dalit lives in their entirety; their histories, their contributions to education, art, and society and not just the challenges they face,” says Natarajan, also the curator of the exhibition. In Petrishia Melodi Dorcas's installation titled Gurnathan, a coffin filled with discarded clothes serves as a powerful metaphor for identity and for lives rendered

Caste unmasked (Clockwise from left) Ambedkarite Lo-fi Girl by Priyanka Paul; The Last Liberation by Yuvadharani; and Ambedkar Utopias by Priyanka Paul. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

invisible. “I have used this installation to talk about the ongoing war and the countless lives lost in this war,” she says. The mound of worn garments evokes layers of the accumulated histories: bodies, work, and personal stories compressed and carried over time.

A resident of North Chennai's Vyasarpadi, J Cathrine Jessica's work forefronts her childhood experiences into an installation. Her work is deeply rooted in personal memory and lived experience. In this particular installation, she has shown her home, “during the monsoon season, rainwater and sewage would mix and overflow, flooding the streets. From a young age, I witnessed people losing their belongings and basic necessities because of it”.

In Yuvadharani Sivakumar's series of paintings, she delves into the female body, menstruation, pleasure, and emotional vulnerability which she describes as a way of questioning, holding on to emotions that she cannot fully articulate.

Artist Priyanka Paul takes an edgy turn with their artwork, titled Ambedkarite lo-fi Girl, drawing on lo-fi aesthetics to explore themes of social justice, self-exploration, and understanding marginalisation.

These works do more than occupy space; they insist on being seen and heard.

The Whole Story, is on at the Lalit Kala Akademi till April 18 from 11am to 7pm.. Entry is free.

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It is not often that Tamil Nadu's voters see a sitting Chief Minister in tailored trousers while addressing the public. Nor have chudidars traditionally been part of the campaign trail. Bright, eye-catching colours have become the new political uniform, and we even have reels teaching supporters how to replicate the look of the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) chief.

Who would have thought we would live in a world where a bridal house creates an ornate TVK blouse, complete with two squirrels rising from a fan of whistles?

In 2015, *The Hindu* published an article titled 'Clothing reality: TN politicians bid for new appeal', on the transformation of the traditional Tamil dress code in politics. In it, reporter B Kolappan spoke about how leaders were trading the spotless white khadi shirt and dhoti for pants. This era saw a slow, hesitant change in attire by a daring few.

Now, 11 years later, access to platforms like Instagram and X, along with the rise of fast fashion delivered to one's doorstep, has brought global aesthetics into everyday wardrobes at accessible prices.

Gen Z voters, in particular, are approaching the election on their terms – through AI campaigns, holograms, and theatrics staged for Instagram reels, like riding a cycle through a highway.

Ahead of the 2026 Assembly Elections, wholesale and retail shopkeepers across Tamil Nadu, who trade in political party-branded shirts, mufflers, towels, dhotis and saris, say that remarkable changes have been witnessed this time around.

A quick Google search lists several hundred sellers who have stocked up on Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) saris and shirts with the rising sun incorporated in design; colourful red and yellow TVK memorabilia with the whistle symbol; and the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) and Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) alliance's two leaves and lotus symbol on clothes. Godown Street in Sowcarpet spills over with mufflers and towels in party colours. This, however, is routine during elections.

This time, we are seeing numerous stylistic alterations including screenprinting the faces of leaders like Chief Minister MK Stalin and actor-politician Vijay, and customised logos on attire; checkered thundus (towels) like the one worn by AIADMK chief Edappadi K Palaniswami; colourful mufflers; hoodies

bearing the names of political parties and constituencies; and most importantly, pants, on the campaign trail.

Back in the day
Author and professor AR Venkatachalapathy, who wrote the book *Tamil Characters: Personalities, Politics, Culture*, published by Pan Macmillan India, speaks of the early aesthetic of the Dravidian movement where black and red were significant anchors of the Dravida Kazhagam (DK) party started by Periyar EV Ramasamy.

"This was back in 1944. The DK was insistent about wearing these colours but when a rift between Anna and Periyar occurred, he [the latter] turned up at party conferences without the black shirt. This furthered the rift," he says.

After DMK's split from DK, the party moved towards white shirts and dhotis, since black was part of DK's uniform. Anna helmed and organised a significant party-led campaign to support handloom weavers in the early 1950s when the industry was in crisis. Back then leaders and party workers wore only handloom.

Academician P Ramajayam, says that the introduction of different kinds of fabric, particularly synthetic mix, caused a deviation from the hard-line stance that the DMK once took about using handloom. "It is more expensive and time consuming to wash and maintain a white-and-white outfit. Nobody today has the time to starch," he says.

Except members of the Congress, who continue to wear khadi.

Moving on
Harikishan TV, a fifth-generation entrepreneur running Krishna Emporium at Godown Street in Sowcarpet, says that the primary material used now is polyester, especially since cotton prices have shot up. "We stock party garments through the year, but



While campaigning, I have noticed that people are warm irrespective of what I wear. I just like wearing black and red

DR V GOKILAMANI
Contesting from Avinashi



Styling the ballot (Clockwise from far left) Politicians Udhayanidhi Stalin; MK Stalin; Narendra Modi; D Jayakumar and Porkodi Armstrong; Thol Thirumavalavan; Dr Ezhilan Naganathan; Vijay; Dr V Gokilamani; Seeman; Edappadi K Palaniswami and Tamilisai Soundararajan. THE HINDU ARCHIVES, PTI AND REUTERS



Vote couture



during election season, we place bulk orders in Surat where screen printing is cheaper. Designs, particularly for the pallu and the shirt pocket, are sent in advance and stocks arrive right in time for election season," he says.

Hari adds that quality depends on how much party workers and candidates are willing to spend. "The DMK usually asks for higher-quality saris, priced upwards of ₹200, while parties like the Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK) and Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) are usually in the ₹160 to ₹200 range."

Wholesaler R Suresh Kumar, who runs Niew Shankar Store on the same street, says retailers across Tamil Nadu buy clothing to distribute in smaller towns, cities and villages. DMK, AIADMK and TVK paraphernalia have dominated sales. "The first two have consistent sales every year but the DMK checked towels, a new entrant to the market is doing well," he says. Retailers from Thoothukudi, Salem, and Vriddhachalam confirm this shift.

R Sankar of Sri Lakshanaa Sarees in Elampillai, Salem district, says his TVK and DMK saris are sold out. They

highlight saris that have Vijay's face printed across the body. "The DMK saris have Stalin and Udayanidhi Stalin as people prefer to see both of them together. All our saris have a synthetic tussar finish," he says, adding that the reel they posted on Instagram with Vijay's face went viral. The saris with the faces retail at ₹599 but saris with just the party symbol sell anywhere between ₹100 and ₹300.

Cashing in on the mania is M Madhumathi of Maya's Bridal House in Velachery who insists that she is not a Vijay fan though everyone else around her is. "Business was slow so I designed an ornate blouse using aari work with the TVK flag on the back flanked by two squirrels [his fans are called 'anils' or squirrels in Tamil], rising from a pool of whistles [the party's symbol]. The blouse costs ₹12,000 and nobody has purchased it but my reel has reached some 37 lakh views and I have gotten many inquiries since," she says.

Long before Vijay officially announced the name of his party, M Ajay Karthick from Thoothukudi began selling shirts with a red embroidered Vijay on the shirt lapel. "We run Master Clothing and we are big



fans. We screen print T-shirts and hoodies too but only for bulk orders. People often want their names and their constituency names on our T-shirts. The Thalpathy shirt first sold for ₹800 and saw tremendous demand but copies of designs have plagued us," he sighs.

Shirts that are convenient
"It is all about convenience," says DMK's incumbent MLA from Thousand Lights constituency, Dr Ezhilan Naganathan, a senior physician. This MLA who is contesting from the same constituency this year often sports his party colours in the inner fold of his shirt collar. "As someone who is a politician and a practising



A shirt is essential for a professional look. I contacted my tailor and designer who made some sample shirts. We settled on one where the sleeves and the collar reveal my party colours

DR EZHILAN NAGANATHAN
Contesting from Thousand Lights

doctor, I have to step in and out of clinics. A shirt is essential for a professional look. I contacted Rafi, a tailor and designer who made some sample shirts. We settled on one where the sleeves and the collar reveal my party colours," he says.

Dr V Gokilamani, who is contesting from Avinashi, is DMK's youngest nominee at 28, and can often be seen in black saris or salwar kameez. "It is a personal preference and is dependent on the occasion. While campaigning, I have noticed that people are warm irrespective of what I wear. I just like wearing black and red," she says.

The same can be said of Porkodi Armstrong, wife of slain Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) leader K Armstrong, contesting from Thiru Vi Ka Nagar constituency. She wears neutral colours and salwars in her campaign, and has said that she seeks a broader mandate to champion the rights of Dalits and other marginalised communities.

J Balasubramaniam, Assistant Professor, Department of Journalism, Madurai Kamaraj University, says that among the first things told to young Dalit children in the 1990s was "to

always ensure that everyone is highly educated and is always impeccably dressed". It prevents any barriers to entry, he says. He gives K Krishnasamy of Puthiya Tamilagam (PT), who used to wear pants and Reebok and Nike shoes to the Assembly, as an example: "Cartoons were drawn in Tamil magazines commenting on his style. A leader from an oppressed community was wearing chic clothes," he says.

Balasubramaniam says he and VCK leader Thol Thirumavalavan follow revolutionary leader BR Amedkar's style, dressing in crisp shirts, blazers, and ties. He adds, "Thirumavalavan's look has changed from the dark shirts folded above his elbow when he first began his career. Today, he sports light shirts in blue, cream and white. He has always dressed sharply though. Today the letters VCK or the party's star symbol are often embroidered on his pocket."

Pocket notes
Dr Ezhilan says that he has observed several members of the party replicate this signature design, particularly on the pocket. "Everyone has their own style. The Deputy Chief Minister [Udhayanidhi Stalin] wears the symbol of the Youth Wing on his T-shirt, while TRB Rajaa [Minister for Industries] can be seen wearing the party colours on the lapel," he says. Durai Vaiko of Marumalarchi Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (MDMK) flaunts the band of his party flag on the arm of his shirt, while Bharatiya Janata Party members including Tamilisai Soundararajan, L Murugan and K Annamalai, sport the lotus prominently as a scarf over their shoulders.

Senior journalist RK Radhakrishnan says that this exercise in personal branding began in 2014 when Narendra Modi took a selfie outside a polling booth with the lotus that ended up going viral online. Soon, he used the party symbol in his garments and insisted that senior leadership follow suit. "This has trickled down to Tamil Nadu too," he says.

Winds of change
Eleven years since publishing his article, have B Kolappan's observations on this functional shift towards convenient clothing in politics changed? "People might be wearing pants, jeans, and T-shirts but there is something that we are forgetting. The idea of identity. Some things – the language we speak, the food we eat – remain consistent despite changing times. The dhoti is like that. Despite the fact that pants are now being utilised, the charm of the dhoti remains. It is why politicians continue to wear it in the Assembly," he says, adding "Outside of the State, it is central to our identity."

STEP OUT



Mystical treat
In the mood for some magic? This special series of magic shows will present a combination of illusion and entertainment. Performed by Pourush Sorcar, grandson of

the legendary magician PC Sorcar, the show will present classic and contemporary tricks. Magician Dhaya will join him on stage. @Museum Theatre, Egmore. April 18 to June 7, on Saturdays and Sundays only, at 5pm and 7.15pm. Tickets on BookMyShow. For details, call 8939390999.



Festive Punjabi spread
The Kitchen by Chef Deepa Arora offers a curated festive menu this week to celebrate Tamil New Year. Available till April 18, the menu features traditional Punjabi dishes such as Amritsari lassi, malai paneer tikka, tandoori cauliflower, paneer lababdar, corn palak and dal makhani, served alongside vegetable pulao and tandoori laccha paratha. Dessert is angoori jamun rabri. Offered in two sizes, for two (₹2,100) and for five (₹3,500). For booking, call 9363544123.



Craft your own candles
Jayashree Murali, founder, Havishaa, offers a beginner-friendly candle-making workshop to introduce participants to the basics of soy wax candle-making including fragrance blending and pouring techniques. The workshop will be conducted in English, Tamil, and Hindi, and the fee is ₹1,600, inclusive of material. @Backyard, Adyar. On April 18, from 10am to 12.30pm. To register, call 7358458117.



Korean showcase
The Consulate-General of the Republic of Korea in Chennai, in collaboration with the InKo Centre and K-wave group, organised a two-day Korean cultural festival on April 10 and 11. Held at Express Avenue Mall, nearly 2,000 attendees participated. Held alongside the K Lifestyle in Chennai 2026 fair by KOTRA, the event highlighted the city's growing interest in Korean culture and reinforced cultural and economic ties between Korea and India.



We drop by Adisil, a Sri Lankan refugee-run restaurant at Ripon Buildings for coconut rice and fish fry

A photograph of a meal served on a large, round, silver-colored metal plate. In the center is a large, rounded mound of white, fluffy rice. To the right of the rice is a bowl of orange-colored curry, garnished with green herbs. Below the rice is a small, round metal bowl containing a light-colored chutney or dip. A silver-colored spoon rests on the left side of the plate. The background is a dark, textured surface.

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A vibrant, stylized painting by a woman, featuring a green-skinned figure holding a parrot, surrounded by colorful patterns and figures. The artwork is rich in detail, with a green-skinned woman in a blue patterned sari holding a green parrot. The background is a dense, colorful collage of patterns and figures, including a pink figure and a yellow figure. The style is reminiscent of traditional Indian folk art, with bold colors and intricate patterns.

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Bread and butter

Why Rajkummar Rao turned producer with his latest *Toaster*, which also stars Archana Puran Singh and Abhishek Banerjee

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After his turn as a massy action hero in *Maalik*, Rajkummar Rao returns to comedic chaos in his upcoming Netflix film, *Toaster*. He plays a middle-class miser so obsessed with tracking his expenses that

special is that it marks the debut of Rao and his actor-wife Patralekhaa as producers. “We both have been actors for some time, and we know that it is a natural progression to start producing. But it didn’t work out at that time, so we started again some years later and came up with a name for the banner, Kampa Films, which is a combination of our mothers’ initials,” says Rao. Does being a producer add anything to his perspective as an actor while working on set? Rao is quick to say no; however, his co-star Abhishek Banerjee jokingly interjects, “He used to count the number

of Diet Cokes I had.” As the laughter fades away, Rao continues, “It is a tough job to be a producer; it is the easiest to be an actor, where you come on set, do your job, take your money and leave. There’s no extra stress. But being a producer is a 24/7 job.” For Archana, the decision to be part of the film was simple. “I was sold on the fact that Rajkummar Rao was the hero, as I enjoyed working with him in *Vicky Vidya Ka Woh Wala Video*. If he is convinced about a script, it gives me so much faith that it’s going to be something different,” she says. The decision was personal for Abhishek, a long-time friend of



he goes on a trail to look for a toaster that he gave as a wedding gift to a couple who break off their marriage. The dark comedy has been directed by Vivek Daschaudary and also stars Sanya Malhotra, Abhishek Banerjee, Archana Puran Singh, Farah Khan, Jitendra Joshi and Upendra Limaye in pivotal roles. Apart from its crackling premise, what makes the film

Funny lines
Rajkummar Rao in *Toaster*; (below) a still from the sets. NETFLIX

Rao and Patralekhaa. “It was not a career move; there was no strategy,” he says. Their on-screen banter promises to be striking even in *Toaster*. The actors had earlier lent life to some of the funny scenes in the *Stree* films, where the humour was guided by how the two discovered their characters’ traits. Banerjee feels that their on-screen chemistry is aided by their off-screen bond built on trust. “There have been times when I improvised something in a scene, and the co-actor got offended. But with Rajkummar, there is no fear of improvising because I know we’ll play along. It is a basic trust exercise that actors are taught across the world,” Banerjee says.

Rajkummar Rao has shown his tilt towards comedy in some of his recent films. The actor, who started out with a series of reflective roles in *Shahid* (2012), *Citylights* (2014), *Newton* (2017) and *Aligarh* (2015), has become the face of the middle-class man in small-town comedies like *Bareilly Ki Barfi* (2017), *Bhool Chuk Maaf* (2025) and *Vicky Vidya Ka Woh Wala Video* (2024). How does he differentiate between these similar roles?

“All of them are different stories and milieus. There is no technique to my acting; it is just about being present in the moment,” he says, adding that he looks for something new in his characters, like making him a Mithun Chakraborty fan in *Ludo* or in *Bareilly Ki Barfi*, where he put in a touch of flamboyance. “If there is an opportunity for that in the script, then I will do it. But you cannot do that in every film. It will look weird. I don’t want to be known as someone who does something ‘extra’ in every film,” Rao concludes.

Toaster is streaming on Netflix.

Weight and watch

Bigg Boss-fame ‘Vikkals’ Vikram turns hero with a new Tamil rom-com



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Popular Tamil stand-up comedian ‘Vikkals’ Vikram is turning hero.

After a few months inside the *Bigg Boss* house, a phase that gave him reach and exposure, Vikram Arul Vidyapathi is set to play the lead role in a Tamil film titled *Light Weight, Baby!*. “I’m looking forward to start shoot on this film later this month. It’s a rom-com, and will focus on the romance between a wannabe stand-up comedian and a female bodybuilder,” he says.

Directed by KC Guru, who has worked as an assistant in Kannada films in the past, the romantic comedy will be shot in locations in Bengaluru and Chennai. “Apparently, the director just typed ‘Chennai stand-up comedians’ on Google, because he had written such a lead role, and my profile showed up. I liked the script; it has nice moments and scope for a lot of humour too.” *Light*

Weight, Baby!, produced by Hitha Studios, will have music by Saravanan Subramaniam and cinematography by Pramod Kotiyan. The female lead will be played by debutant Arthy Krishna.

Initially known for his stand-up content and viral musical Reels, Vikram’s entry into the *Bigg Boss* house was a big turning point. He was also among the top few contestants in the last season of the reality show, with fans discussing his transparent behaviour and activities inside the house in great detail.

“Life has certainly changed after those 100-plus days,” admits Vikram. “Earlier, fans knew me through my content, but through this show, they came to know about my personality. Apart from the interesting experiences, its exposure has been far-reaching; these days, I’m listening to a lot of scripts and will be finalising some of them soon. I also hope to stage my next stand-up show later this year.”

Flavours that pop

Kilpauk’s new restaurant Poppadum serves vegetarian food shaped by regional influences with a focus on playful textures, from khichiyas to thattai tostadas



What’s on your plate?
Boujje Bombay toast at Poppadum. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

white dal makhani. “We see so much of the regular kaali dal makhni so we replaced it with white urad. It’s still creamy and rich but its more garlicky and topped with a chilli oil,” he says.

Poppadum steps into a space Chennai’s restaurant scene is only just beginning to open up to. In the part of the city where dining out still often defaults to comfort classics, this feels like a small push forward. The menu’s strength lies in its detail of layering textures and flavours. It reflects the way the restaurant has been thought through. “Everyone keeps asking, ‘Is the city ready?’ The city will be ready only when someone attempts and tries pushing new ideas,” says Abbas.

It is a good thing desserts go straight to the heart, because there is no room left. The falooda barf gola manages to stay refreshing without tipping into cloying sweetness. The filter coffee pudding on the other hand is decadent with coffee soaked biscuits, mascarpone cream and chocolate almond chikki bits to add crunch. The crunch is a constant at Poppadum.

Poppadum is at 12/3A, Ormes Road, next to Attic Fabric Studio, Kilpauk. A meal for two costs ₹2,200. For reservations, call 9025656811.



A dash of yellow
Sakthivel S with a copy of his wedding invitation outside the Chepauk stadium. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The perfect match

This Chennai groom’s CSK-themed wedding invite is winning hearts

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Sakthivel S, a cost accountant from Thiruvannamiyur, is busy distributing his wedding invitation cards. But it is no ordinary card. The invitation for his big day is peppered with yellow. In a city where cricket borders on religion, Sakthivel’s card is a colourful, wacky homage to the Chennai Super Kings (CSK).

Designed like an IPL ticket, the invitation mentions the groom (Sakthivel) and bride (Santhoshini) as the ‘Chennai Super Kings’ and ‘Chennai Super Queens’. With a caricature of them wearing the yellow jersey, the card also features a picture of the trophy-lifting moment of IPL 2023, apart from photos of Sakthivel painted in yellow during a match and with his idol, MS Dhoni. “I love my wedding card,” beams



Sakthivel, “It truly captures the essence of how much I have supported the men in yellow over the years.” This invitation is the brainchild of graphic designer Kishore K, who runs Perambur-based Kalyanamkrafts. “Keeping the IPL craze in mind, I worked on a trial card featuring the Chennai Super Kings. When I posted a video about that on social media, I received several requests from fans,” he reveals.

One of them was from Sakthivel, who was planning to wed in April. “It was a unique request, but it aligned with what I already had in mind,” says Kishore, who went to customise the card according to the needs of the client. Having printed 100 cards at ₹45 each, Kishore today also has requests from fans of Royal Challengers Bangalore (RCB) and Mumbai Indians (MI) to design similar cards for special occasions.

Sakthivel, meanwhile, hopes to distribute this card not just among his friends and family but also to the CSK management and Dhoni himself. Apart from his fascination for Dhoni, Sakthivel – who is also a wicket-keeper batsman himself – loves the Chennai Super Kings for its ‘family-like atmosphere’. “It’s well

known that most players treat this team like family and keep praising it, despite moving on to other franchises.. But the management has also cared for fans; they even once arranged a train for fans when we played a game away from Chennai. So, CSK is – and will always be – special.” And now, it’s part of his big day as well.

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There should always be something crunchy on your plate.

It is that textural contrast that makes every dish at Chennai’s latest vegetarian restaurant Poppadum, ‘pop’. “I married into a Sindhi family and now I cannot eat anything without some crunch,” says Abbas Shahzad, owner of Poppadum. And true to his word, every dish has a crisp element.

This sets the tone for how the menu works. Poppadum is not positioned as ‘modern Indian’ – Abbas is careful about that label. Instead, he calls it ‘Indian-inspired’, keeping things approachable even as the food pushes the envelope. “I’ve grown up in Kilpauk and spent a large part of my life here,” he says,

explaining why he chose the neighbourhood. “The menu is inspired from different regions of India without drawing from one community. So these are familiar flavours being done differently from what is already available in this part of the city,” he adds.

As the music shifts from Black Eyed Peas’ ‘I Gotta Feeling’ to ‘Dil Se’, the burrata masala pappad is placed in front of us. Smoked pumpkin purée, cherry tomato salad and Congress peanuts, topped with creamy burrata and chilli crisp, and served with a garlic papad: this is what your regular masala papad aspires to be.

One of the dishes, inspired by Abbas’ mother-in-law’s dal pakwan, leans simpler, comforting, and familiar, while the thattai tostada, with melted brie, pineapple jam, pickled chillies and hot honey, swings the other way, packing

a sharp sweet-heat punch.

The railway beetroot cutlets, crisp on the outside, echo family holidays spent on trains, and come with a sharp red chilli peanut sauce. For those willing to push the heat, Naga chilli mushrooms are a must-try. One bite is just not enough, even as it burns your tongue.

“There needs to be some level of yourself that bleeds into the space,” says Abbas, as the playlist moves through underrated tracks from the 1990s, 2000s and early 2010s. “These are just songs we listen to,” he laughs, as the main course begins to fill the table: smoked masoor dal pulao, malai koftas, parmesan and scallion parotta, chilli paratha, and